From

Sex, When You Don't Feel Like It:

The Truth About Mismatched Libido

& Rediscovering Desire

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CHAPTER 8



The Body Speaks

> Sex is emotion in motion.
>
> —Mae West

Before we press on, I invite you to stop for a moment and notice your body. By notice I mean bring your attention to it. Feel it. Its weight. Its texture. Its power. That despite the odds, you are here as a result of thousands of years of evolution, the most advanced form of human life to ever grace the Earth. After the heady learning of sex science in chapters 4 and 5, then the intellectual and reflective self-inquiry of chapters 6 and 7, from here we begin to form a relationship with a vital aspect of erotic intelligence that is often overlooked in traditional sex therapy and indeed most talk-based therapies all together. The wisdom of the body isn't new but, in recent years, has gained a lot of traction in trauma therapy theory as well as its application alongside practices like mindfulness to bring a more holistic understanding of the breadth of the human experience. In this chapter we'll look at how our relationship with our bodies offers us valuable information about sex,

pleasure, and satisfaction, and why learning to read your body's language is a crucial step in moving closer to your desire, your passion, and, ultimately, your pleasure. We'll learn some practical tools to get started with using your body as an instrument of erotic knowledge, and we'll unpack how the discomfort we may feel about our sexual inadequacies are not as pathological as we are led to believe.

Having a body is integral to having desire. You could say that the *essence* of desire is embodiment plus action. Desire is a *doing* word, not just an idea. Infused by motivation and incentive *within your body*, this is the organism that transports you around the planet and the vehicle through which you experience the physical world, including the erotic. Desire is personal. Desire gives us purpose and inspires us to action. The desire to consume, the desire to own or have, the desire to *be* (hot, successful, beautiful, rich) influence so many of our day-to-day choices and actions. Owning a home, the latest gadget, having the perfect body, the "hot" partner, reveling in sporting achievements, the correct diet, a new car, or the perfect job are desires many of us are increasingly familiar with. These desires can be fickle or pursued over a lifetime. But our relationship with desire is more complex than simply "wanting" alone. It exists within an environment that encourages or denies it. Depending upon our gender, orientation, age, size, ability, location, resources, race, and the freedoms afforded to us through that, we are at the mercy of how desire influences us and the decisions we make.

In chapter 5, we learned that embodiment is an action that involves more than just the body. We learned how the body is situated within an environment, and like the flying bird, the flight process takes place only within an environment that allows it. Without the interaction between the whole bird and its environment, flight does not happen. When we understand erotic desire as an *embodied action*, we too must recognize that to embody erotic desire, we must interact with the environment that contains it. But when the environment we live neither inspires nor encourages desire in an erotic context, we internalize the taboo in order to make sense of it. In other words, we adapt by becoming disembodied. It's easier to disconnect than recalibrate. We believe we are flawed and we *become* the problem, rather than scrutinizing the systems and beliefs that encouraged it. Disembodiment manifests with stealth. We know we are in its grip when we feel shame or disconnection from our bodies or about our desires. Age, physicality, ability, relationship, and status all affect our access to pleasure. Socially speaking,

those in partnerships are considered more deserving of sex and are granted more permission to access erotic pleasure than those who access it via masturbation or paid escort services. Our social merging of love and sex means that sex for some is harder to come by when they do not have access to love. We have collectively made room for sex in the context of a loving relationship, but are still challenged by its presence outside of this. For most of us, pleasure is believed to be something we *earn* rather than something we have a right to. Those more deserving—the slim, young, able-bodied, and so on—are closer to the front of the line than those whose sexuality or body shape sits outside the mainstream view of sexual freedom or desirability. These ideas can have an effect on how we experience desire if we feel that we are unworthy of sex and pleasure.

When experienced in context, desire becomes much more complex than simply being horny or not. How we experience our bodies viscer-ally and environmentally, combined with our ability to even recognize and accept our bodies' desires is one thing, then how they are situated within our environment is a whole other thing that none of us are exempt from. When the environment we inhabit is not conducive to the emergence of erotic desire, it is increasingly difficult, but not impossible, to connect with this part of ourselves.

When women are forced to continuously deny themselves food or pleasure to prove their femininity and attractiveness (e.g., if you express your desires you're a" slut," you're "too much," or simply "fat") when men are required to deny their feelings and emotions to fulfill the same ludicrous gender stereotypes (e.g., real men want sex, not intimacy or affection), and when non-binary and gender diverse people are robbed of sexuality all together because their existence is just too challenging for the mainstream to comprehend, let alone love, we become trapped in a system that denies the most visceral parts of ourselves at the expense of being accepted and accepting of ourselves. Women become conditioned from an early age that *being desired* is desirable. The nature of subjective erotic desire is foreign to many women. From a young age, girls are rewarded for denying their desires and eroticism to prove their value and worthiness (as wives) later in life. It's no surprise to me that when I ask women what they want sexually, many of them simply respond with: "I don't know." Erotic self-inquiry has never been afforded to them. On the other hand, the versions of desire men are encouraged to pursue are narrow and marked by goals pertaining to

achievement and conquest rather than embodied connection. They may know what they are *supposed* to want, but things come tumbling down when they experience a discrepancy between their actual desires and social expectations. When asking men how they *feel*, as opposed to what they *think*, about sex, they will often respond like women: "I don't know." That knowledge has been obscured from the minute they learned that being a "man" meant disconnecting from themselves. Similarly true of gender non-conforming people, as explained by Lucie Fielding in her book *Trans Sex* when she asks, "What if, indeed, the alleviation of gender dysphoria didn't imply sexual losses, but rather the opening onto new possibilities for embodied ecstasy, facilitated by gender euphoria?"[1]

Disembodiment is the physical response to a social agreement that the body is unsafe and sex is shameful or dangerous. Expressions of pure pleasure are, by and large, confronting to those unaccustomed to them. Such expressions are considered shameful and are cast outward, away from ourselves and our communities. This is especially evident when we consider how sex workers are depicted in most cultures, the embodiment of shame that is not revered but reviled the world over. To allow connection with this part of ourselves is terrifying for many. As individuals, there is no incentive to challenge this until the space between our inner erotic and outer physical worlds become intolerable. This is an internal process not visible to the eye, which is also what makes it so treacherous. Subtle reminders of not being desirable or desired, of not being good or worthy enough, of not being eligible to be the desirer because of some shortcoming or simply the absence of erotic privilege to freely choose what you desire because your body doesn't meet an ideal standard of beauty, age, conformity, or function, eventually build a protective barrier making us numb to our inner world. We operate on auto-pilot, and personalized erotic wisdom becomes harder to access. Much like the brakes mechanism, this process begins to shut our eroticism down.

For those with "conventional" bodies, the discomfort of disembodiment may not be acute but rather a state of normality that remains undiagnosed until a catalyst for change, such as a breakdown in relationship or problems with sexual performance, emerges. High functioning, well-respected, socially agile people are no less susceptible to erotic disembodiment; because, this process happens inwardly. The external appearance doesn't reflect the internal experience. For people whose difference is externally visible—

people with disabilities, fat people, trans and non-binary people, older people—or those whose bodies feel like a war zone due to abuse and rape or where pleasure has not existed for a very long time, may have learned to tune out of the body for protection. It's safer to disengage.

Before we diagnose ourselves or our partners with "low libido," let's consider all this prior to such hasty statements. Let's consider just how likely *spontaneous desire* is to manifest under these conditions and the extent to which "spontaneity" is a prerequisite for great sex. One of the greatest paradoxes of the human condition is that of our capacity for thought and meaning to the disadvantage of the body through which we experience our lives. Throughout history, the body has been downplayed and undervalued in its ability to produce or hold wisdom and knowledge, as distinct from divine wisdom, or, more recently, logic and science. Previously, guiding principles of conduct and morality were embedded in religious scriptures. In the late nineenth century, science became the leading authority able to determine what a body was and was not capable of.[2] In other words, the body has always belonged either to God or science. There has never been a time in Western history that the body truly belonged to the person who inhabits it.

The Origins of Disembodiment

We are not born into the world separated from our knowledge of pleasure and our body, nor are we born with blockages in our ability to read our body's language and interpret messages of embodiment. We are born whole and integrated, but over time this knowledge is systematically undone each time we experience an individual visceral response that challenges moral conventions. In short, this knowledge is undone in micro-judgments, over and over, once we cease being solely the apple of our parents' eye, (if indeed we ever were) and become a member of society.

For instance, in order to be loved and accepted we learn that chewing with our mouths closed conveys refinement and that sitting with legs apart is acceptable for boys but not for girls, whether it's comfortable or not. We learn that genitals are dirty and anuses are even worse. Girls learn that painful sex is "normal" with no incentive to discover what creates pleasure. Boys learn that sex for girls is painful with no incentive to question it. We are reminded that farting is unacceptable and being fat is disgusting and the result of laziness or a lack of self-control. We learn from a young age that masturbation is unacceptable in public and, in some cases, unacceptable at

all times. To transgress any of these is to risk social exclusion and, in doing so, we learn to cut off from our sensations and embodied desires.

This is not just a Western phenomenon. All cultures develop rules of social conduct in order to keep communities organized. Some are useful, others are not. While rules vary from culture to culture, what they all have in common is reflecting a community's values. They describe what a society believes *should* be most important, rather than anything necessarily factual or evidence-based. Consequently, social rules pay very little homage to embodied wisdom and even less to Eros, because at no time in recorded human history has this knowledge been revered—until now.

Time for Reflection

In chapter 6 we looked at our personal values and how they inform our lives. From here, take some time to reflect on some of the messages and values you have absorbed from your culture about sex, gender, bodies, desire, erotic privilege, who deserves pleasure, who does not, how sex should be, and for whom. Some of these ideas I have introduced in this chapter, and there are likely some that are unique to your culture, community, and context. This might be an exercise you practice over several days or weeks. It can be overwhelming to digest just how much we have absorbed about sex and the body through our cultural context and just how normal it's become to default to shame and stigma when discussing pleasure and desire. Write down some of your reflections in your notebook. Notice how your body feels when you connect to some of these realizations. It's OK to feel many conflicting feelings at once about this, especially if you grew up in a religious environment, in which case this may be extra challenging. This is not about right versus wrong. It's about unpacking what you have inherited through no fault of your own, while giving you a chance to explore how these values may have influenced your beliefs about sex, pleasure, and desire.

The Body as a Vehicle of Desire and Knowledge

Ask any bodyworker and they will tell you infinite stories of how different massage and body work techniques produce a variety of emotional responses in their clients. Responses that transcend remedial pain relief to involuntary

release of stored emotion and somatic history. Acupuncturists describe floods of tears. Rolfers witness coughing fits. Practitioners of Alexander Technique facilitate ease with blocked communication. Anecdotally, the lists grow each year. This increases significantly when the attention shifts to the pelvis, a phenomenon also recorded by Dr. van der Kolk's trauma team at the Trauma Center in Massachusetts.[3] What we know now is that information that orients us toward well-being is stored within the body and in order to access its wisdom, we must consult it directly. There is an increasing body of evidence arising from the world of psychiatry and neuroscience that describes in detail how the relationship between the body and well-being is mirrored within the brain. The understanding is that our well-being is bidirectional. That is to say, information about our well-being travels from the brain to the body, but it also travels from the body back to the brain.[4] Knowledge is not just one way. Our capacity for reorienting toward the body, desire, and, ultimately, pleasure is more multifaceted than simply mind over matter. We can actually change our brains by changing our habits. This echoes what the science tells us as described in chapter 5. Our attitude *really* is everything, and our attitude is so much more than just our thoughts. It's also our bodies. Our environments. Our values. Our beliefs. Our spirituality. Our identities. Our privileges. And, as you're discovering, our sex education.

The *rewire your brain* argument has been used with vigor over the past ten years or so by extremist anti-porn crusaders to remind us how such online activity affects our brains. While online activity *does* affect our brains, what is also true is that *anything and everything* we do rewires our brains. The anti-porn brigade is not telling the whole story. Social media rewires your brain. Eating potato chips rewires your brain. Reading the Bible rewires your brain. Taking time off work rewires your brain. Attending a funeral rewires your brain. A global pandemic rewires your brain. Sitting in front of a computer writing a book is rewiring my brain right now. But the good news is that science is telling us that none of this is permanent. What was wired can be unwired, and it needn't be a top-down process; bottom up works equally as well. This means we can rewire the inhibitions caused by our brakes mechanism by thinking and talking about it; through the mind. We can also change its effects through the way we engage and experience our *bodies* sexually.

In order to develop and expand sexual curiosity, it's helpful to connect and stay with the sensations in our bodies. To experience erotic desire, it

helps to explore sensations more fully as a pathway to greater self-understanding. Many psychotherapeutic and therapeutic disciplines such as Gestalt, Emotion-Focused Therapy, Acceptance and Commitment Therapy, Sensorimotor Therapy, Somatic Experiencing, Focusing and Hakomi Method, to name a few, all invite tuning into the body and staying with its responses as a way of making sense of the somatic experiences within. While none of them have any explicit frameworks for addressing sex from a *pleasure* perspective, their foundations are solid and can be applied in our domestic erotic contexts, as I will explain shortly.

The solid evidence of somatic therapies presently focuses on its application to trauma and trauma recovery.[5] Reorienting the body to health and calmness via the body prove viable even in the most severe cases of post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). What this implies is that while we know this process works in a trauma recovery context it can also work to reorient us toward pleasure, whether explicit trauma has been present or not.

Growing up as we all have in an environment that enforces disembodiment as a means of social inclusion is, in effect, a traumatic experience. It is not violent in the way many traumas are conventionally imagined, but it's experienced viscerally as a shock to the system. In the same way the bird needs space in order to experience flight, denying the body pleasure offers no way of processing the desires that emerge within us from childhood and beyond. Once the environment no longer supports flight, the bird is captive. In humans, our playful impulses are forced down in a socially prohibitive environment and retired from display. This is how disconnection begins. It explains why so many people struggle with the embodiment of pleasure in their sexual practices. This is especially true of our erotic impulses and impulses of sexuality that defy moral conventions—for example, exploring gender or kink and BDSM, queerness, or homosexuality. In accessing the same principles used in trauma therapy, by tuning into the body for information, we can learn what we need to embody in order to facilitate sensation most useful for developing a language around erotic desire. In working closely with the body and intimacy, trauma is a reason to go slowly, but not a reason to avoid. For others who have simply lost their way, recalibrating the relationship to the body is a liberating process, but one that requires a delicate shift in building capacity from listening with the ears, to capacity managed through acknowledging sensation.

In the past twenty years more has been written on the wisdom of the body, but seldom in an erotic or sexualized context. It seems that bodymind (a term referring to the intelligence of the body) researchers, including the newest recruits of the mindfulness and neuroscience movements are, like the rest of society, deeply uncomfortable with explorations of sex and sexuality. With the exception of Wilhelm Reich, a mid-twentieth-century Austrian psychoanalyst who studied mental health and orgasm, sexuality and erotic pleasure are conspicuously absent from discussions of the bodymind in health and well-being literature. From its initial appearance in scientific texts of the early twentieth century, as decades progressed and sexuality was studied, it was spoken of with diminishing detail regarding its relationship to the experience of embodiment.[6] This stigma plays out in bedrooms across the world and is the primary source of the majority of discomfort people feel about managing their sex lives today. We can discuss sex critically and clinically but are profoundly uncomfortable with its relationship to embodiment and pleasure. This is reinforced by the majority of funding received for sex research, which focus almost exclusively on genital function or reproduction with very little on practices such as oral sex, erotic massage, or anal sex; practices that serve solely for erotic pleasure and increasingly sought in porn search engines and in the boudoirs of sex workers across the planet, due to their immense popularity and curiosity. At the time of writing, Sexological Bodywork is the only established somatic therapeutic intervention that invites clients to experience the body through an erotic lens, via the presence of one-way touch designed to encourage deeper connection and wisdom to the body's innate erotic knowledge and needs.

Facilitating Erotic Awakening

When numbness of the body is a response to sexual self-inquiry or a discussion of what we like is met with "I don't know," it's useful to use that information as a starting point for change. Whether cognitive awareness or sensation are blocked, it can be helpful to remember that such disembodiment is likely to be the result of trauma.[7] This is true for people even without recollection of any *explicit* trauma.

All of us have *embodied experiences* of growing up in communities where expression of sexual pleasure was limited and restricted. We know this because all cultures are in some ways to promote social cohesion, there are some benefits. While not everyone internalizes this to the degree that it's

debilitating, almost everyone can recall stories of how they first learned about sex and knew, almost instinctively, that its presence was a source of discomfort.

To manage the discomfort, we learn to disengage. Numbing is effective because we get to tune out. Numbing can be experienced in a physical sense —with no sensation—or in an emotional or cognitive sense, like when people respond with "I don't know" to a question about pleasure, feelings, or desire. Numbing also protects us from getting hurt and being vulnerable. It reduces excitement and anticipation and minimizes the effects of disappointment should they come along. It reduces our need to pay attention, to respond, and, ultimately, to experience ourselves when an anticipated outcome is not actualized, like an orgasm or an erection. When we learn to numb ourselves in order to gain some social advantage, privilege, or, simply, acceptance it's hard to tolerate seeing this embodied in others. And the effect on *our* eroticism and relationship to life is devastating. Just like the bird adjusting to life in a cage, it can survive, but at a cost that only the bird knows—if indeed it dares to feel it. Being numb may be a better option. In order to fit in, we learn to cut off from ourselves and ignore our desires and erotic impulses. This in itself is not a bad skill; the trouble is when it becomes a default rather than something we can turn on and off at will.

Case Study: Lewis

Lewis first started seeing me with his girlfriend when, several years into their relationship, their sex life had started to decline. On paper Lewis had it all. His girlfriend was beautiful, stunning by conventional standards. He had a great job and was respected in his career in law enforcement. But internally, Lewis was extremely uncomfortable with expressing desire. He recognized that if he didn't do anything about it, he would lose her. But his terror was so visceral; it was like he was literally, petrified. His speech was affected. He was slow, uncomfortable with verbal expression and eye contact and this was matched in his body too. The way he moved, the stiffness with which he spoke and walked. Even non-sexual activities indicated a lack of ease in his body. He was simply not comfortable in his skin.

It came as no surprise to me that Lewis experienced frequent problems with early ejaculation and unreliable erections too. Everything in his body was avoiding sex and it was getting out of control. Where his voice was

unable to express what he was feeling, his body did very well. What confused him was that it didn't match what he wanted in his heart.

In Lewis's career in law enforcement he had learned to brace himself to threat. This was a useful skill. A survival skill. His sympathetic nervous system protected him very well. His fight or flight mechanism was finely tuned. He was alert to any oncoming danger and able to move out of harm's way in an instant. From an evolutionary perspective, his body was doing what it needed to do.

The trouble was Lewis was also responding like this during sex and intimacy. His body was expressing what it knew how to do when it came to vulnerability: self-preservation. In order for Lewis to experience the kind of pleasure he longed to feel, he had to learn to tolerate vulnerability in bed as well as protect against it at work. While he was set to "on" mode with his body being unable to soften and relax, his body had adjusted in such a way that any invitation for the relaxation of eroticism meant his body jumped in to protect him. His parasympathetic nervous system needed permission to take over at will, to allow him to relax, become aroused, and enjoy pleasure while also practicing the vulnerability of being sensitive and exposed. Whenever his girlfriend tried to initiate sex, he'd withdraw. He'd shut down, find excuses not to follow through. He was protecting himself from the disappointment of his unreliable genitals and avoiding conversation with her about it to avoid the discomfort of being vulnerable.

Over time, she began to feel it was all happening *because* of her. When I met them, she was convinced he no longer loved her. She thought maybe he was having an affair. She too began to internalize his shame. The lack of embodiment in this relationship was spiraling out of control.

For Lewis, the catalyst for change was that he was going to lose his relationship. He knew he couldn't continue as he was, but he knew no other way. This was his incentive. This was his answer to "Why do you have sex?" This was his motivation and his pathway to desire.

Over time, Lewis learned to pay more attention to his body and what was once stiff, cold, and unreliable, became softer and more receptive. But it took time. He and his girlfriend worked long and hard to create erotic scenarios where he was invited to receive touch without having to "perform" by having an erection or an orgasm. Simply being allowed to "receive" touch without having to do anything in response, meant he was able to practice being both vulnerable and safe at the same time. He learned to allow himself the

practice of receiving without expectation. This was a brand-new experience for Lewis who had no recollection of being traumatized in sex, yet everything within him responded with fear and discomfort. His physical disembodiment was a response to his environment not allowing him to feel vulnerability, excitement, and desire all at the same time. In Lewis's world, vulnerability meant danger and was to be avoided at all costs. Even though it defied logic, he knew he was safe in bed with his girlfriend, his body responded as if the conditions were not right for him to be embodied. Years of being in an environment not conducive to him spreading his wings meant his body seized up. He internalized the desire to reach out and made it safer to not do it, by not allowing himself to feel his body at all. Using this knowledge to move forward, we were able to craft a series of practices which gave Lewis the opportunity to be embodied in an environment that was conducive to curiosity rather than shame or fear. Sometimes the most direct way back to the body is to use it, and reduce the amount of time spent over-analyzing in the head. Let's see how Lewis did this.

Simple Tuning In Practices

When we allow the body to speak, when we tune in to its language, it tells us what we need. One of the most useful introductory practices to help facilitate tuning in to the body is a simple awareness practice. If you are not aware of what your body needs, it's much harder to enjoy it, respond to it, and, indeed, take care of it or share it fully with another. Learning the practice of tuning in is simple. Staying with it is more challenging. It's a process of tuning in, feeling, and noticing. It's an ever-changing process that invites you to pay attention to dynamics and emotions as they occur. What happens after that, is up to you.

Facilitated by breath, attention, and concentration, the purpose is to practice tuning in to the "felt sense" within our bodies. Philosopher Eugene Gendlin first coined the expression "felt sense" to describe a form of visceral communication between the conscious mind and the physical body.[8] This process is essential when relearning a relationship with desire. When sensation is blocked, so too is desire. In much the same way we tune in to a radio or TV signal, tuning into the body requires getting the feedback just right to receive the signal. It can take practice and time to allow the interference of a chattering mind to minimize enough to start getting accurate information.

Get Centered and Breathe

First, read through this activity before you do it. It's useful to have an idea of the whole activity before attempting it. Find somewhere quiet to be still. Either sit or lie down. Take three deep, full breaths. Imagine a balloon within your belly that expands as you breathe in and contracts as you breathe out. If you are a visual person, see the balloon. If you are a sensory person, feel the balloon. If you are an auditory person hear the balloon expanding and contacting. If you are not sure, try all of the techniques and see which resonate. You may need more than three breaths to do all of this. That is OK. In fact, the more you breathe the more you feel. The balloon is simply a metaphor to remind you that the breath needs to be expansive and not shallow and stuck within the chest. It's bigger and makes everything rise and fall. I call this a "centering" breath technique as it helps you get centered.

Scan

When you're ready, run a "scan" of the body. Imagine a scanner literally scanning the entirety of your body, starting from feet, up to the top of your head. As you run the scanner, allow any "felt senses" to emerge. Just notice them. Anything at all. Do not judge or try to interpret. Simply let them emerge. As they emerge, try to find words to describe them. This is the *beginning* of the process of embodiment.

The kinds of things that we register as "felt senses" include:

- air—cool, warm, direction, rush, moist, feathery, intensity
- itch / irritation—mild, angry, irritating, subtle, small, large area
- temperature—warm, cold, hot, cool, clammy, burning, icy, frozen, chills; *comparison:* like a fireplace, oven, camp fire, sunshine, warm meal, slushy, stone, shade
- pressure—sharp, heavy, even, uneven, supportive, crushing, restricting, tight, pulsating, thud, throb
- weight—light, heavy, imbalanced, uneven, stuck
- tension—solid, dense, warm, cold, inflamed, protective, constricting, angry, sad, tight
- pain—ache, sharp, twinge, slight, stabbing, throbbing, dull, comes and goes
- tingling—pins and needles, prickly, vibration, tickling, numb
- size—small, large, huge, tiny

- shape—round, sharp, geometric, flat, circular, blob, mountainous
- motion—static, stationary, circular, erratic, straight, curved, gentle
- speed—fast, slow, still, slow motion
- texture—rough, wood, stone, sandpaper, smooth, silk, liquid
- element—fire, air, earth, water, wood
- color—opaque, gray, red, orange, etc.
- mood / emotion—sinking, drowning, running, pulling in, open, closed, uplifting, sunny day, dark cloud, inviting, shaming, shutting down, inflamed, raging, torrential
- sound—buzzing, singing, ringing, murmuring, humming
- taste—sour, bitter, sweet, salt, tangy
- smell—pungent, sweet, earthy, damp, like dog, like rain, like cut grass
- absence / nothingness—blank, empty, numb, nothing, hollow
- intensity—mild, strong, inconsistent

Describe these sensations out loud and allow yourself to fully feel them. It can be helpful to record yourself on a device during this process if you are alone. The purpose of saying them out loud is to be able to name them and potentially get to know them better the more often they appear. The purpose is not to change them (not at this stage anyway) but simply allow them to be present without judging or trying to alter them. Whether they register as pleasant or unpleasant, the challenge is in being able to stay present to them rather than block them, push them away, or get too attached or distracted by them. When we are able to let sensations arise within us and name them, we are better able to give them meaning, purpose, and understanding. We can better integrate them (like Lewis) to inform motivation: "Why do I have sex?" like we learned all about in chapter 6. In being better equipped to explore the process of embodiment in this way we make the potential to access pleasure and desire more available. Getting used to tuning in to the body allows us to be more aware of its responses to certain kinds of touch or stimulation, whether internal or external.

Try this activity for fifteen minutes a day, every day for a week. Notice what emerges each day and pay attention to any patterns or irregularities that you find as well as consistencies. All of this is great practice for tuning in to the impermanent nature of embodiment as a living, ever-changing being.

Zeroing In

An alternative to the scan is to choose one area at a time and see what emerges when you focus upon it. If you encounter a part of the body that elicits a traumatic or challenging response, do not panic. Place your hand on that part and send your breath to it using your imagination. Remind yourself you are safe and thank the sensation for showing itself. Do not force or press past what you are able to manage comfortably. You may not experience the same sensation every time in that part. Practicing allowing it to emerge is part of making room for embodiment to exist. If you begin to feel too much too soon, switch your attention to another part of your body. If that feels too much, stop. Take a glass of water and recalibrate. Try again another time.

If during zeroing you experience a sensation that is pleasant, neutral, or just plain curious, go into it further. You do this by sending breath to that place via your imagination and increasing the attention you place on it. As you breathe, feel that sensation becoming more magnified in whatever way that resonates for you. Don't worry about it "making sense." It most likely won't—at this stage anyway. We don't ask ourselves why we like the taste of something delicious, we just allow ourselves to enjoy it, so practice the same approach with exploring other sensations beyond taste. Just accept that it's a sensation that is pleasant. Describe it in as much detail as possible to a partner, friend or on your recording device. This allows you to be able to expand the sensation more fully and listen back to it for context and further understanding.

The Grounding Base Breath

Once you have been able to tune in to the body's sensations, you may like to practice amplifying or downplaying them. One of the most effective ways to do this is through breath. Breathing is integral to this practice whether at a beginner or advanced level. The Grounding Base Breath is really useful in helping connect to the body as it involves breathing in such a way that the entire torso and digestive tract is activated all the way from the mouth to the anus (which incidentally are the opposing ends of the exact same tube). Again, find a comfortable position, lying down if you can. Lying down on your back is useful as it forces you to breathe deeply into the lungs and not just shallow at a chest level. Place your feet flat on the floor with your knees bent. If this isn't possible, a chair is also fine, just remember to expand the lungs and belly as you breathe.

Breathe in, connect with the expanding balloon and this time imagine it (in your own way) expanding width ways as before and also length ways. As it expands down the length of your torso, imagine it gently pushing your pelvic floor muscles down and away from the body. Bear down slightly as if you were going to poop (but not so much that you do) and feel your anus puckering out ever so gently, as if it were "kissing" the surface beneath you. Allow yourself to connect with these deep sensations of the pelvic floor being tickled from the inside by your breath. I like to imagine the sound of Barry White's voice in my head for such activities. He knows how get deep, deep, deep, way down low. Then as you exhale, allow the air out of your mouth and feel the pelvic floor muscles and anus return to their regular state again.

Level Up

Once you have the hang of the sensation of breathing and bearing down slightly, try focusing your attention on a slightly exaggerated exhale. In through the nose and out through the mouth. It may be easier to connect with more heightened levels of sensation by exhaling through the mouth. Try and see what feels best for you.

The good thing about working with breath in accessing desire is it gives us something to focus on instead of the racing thoughts of the mind, which may be a distraction from sex and part of the brakes network. Exhaling stimulates the parasympathetic nervous system, which decreases how fast the heart beats, which in turn relaxes us. This is called a "down-regulating" breath as it decreases anxiety and stress within the body. Additionally, the anus is a region that is notoriously tight, and a place where a lot of emotion gets "stuck." It's an area associated with taboo and shame for many people and as a result, gets little attention from medical or even bodymind practitioners. Stress and anxiety have a strong relationship to the gut and the digestive system of which the anus is an important part. For many of us, stress and anxiety are centred around poor gut and anal function. Ever heard the expression "So-and-so is a tight-ass!" or "Such-and-such is so anal"? They're describing someone who is lacking in flexibility, openness, and spirit. While this may not be true literally, tightness in the anus and pelvic floor can stem from insecurity and a reflex to protect, fear and feeling unsafe enough to let go. Tightness in the pelvic floor and the anus in particular can be a hindrance to pleasure and desire and this technique is a gentle and non-

invasive way to get this part of the body to soften, without feeling too confronting or exposing.

The Body Is the Home of Better Sex. Frankly!

Whether explicit trauma is present or not, learning to tune in to the body by imposing relaxation is helpful. Breath can control the brain's stress responses and our ability to control our physical responses. Practicing "down regulating" breath and body techniques are useful for helping us tune in to the "felt sense," especially if there is a little bit of blockage or numbness. An "up-regulating" breath (which emphasizes the inhale), increases intensity and stimulation of the senses, so it's also useful for exaggerating what is present if we want to feel it more. Play with inhalations via the nose and the mouth and see how your body responds differently according to where oxygen enters. As a general rule, more air is taken in via the mouth than the nose. By increasing the amount of oxygen you take in during sex, you can feel more alive within your body. Learning to practice controlling sensations within your body can lead to feeling safer; which can in turn help create more pleasure and desire during sex.

In the next chapter we build on these foundational embodiment skills and, with your permission, level up to more explicit erotic practices. You may like to hang out with this chapter for a while longer before graduating to the next place, or you may like to skip over the explicit sexual stuff entirely. It's really up to you. Practice feeling your body and noticing how it responds to the options created in this book so far and moving forward. Because pleasure matters. Because what you want matters. And because the most important part of desire is honoring yourself in your quest to find it.